Chapter 20

Correction through Meditation: Restoring Compassion

ON 4 NOVEMBER 1993 THE VIPASSANA SADHANA SANSTHAN established contact with the Tihar IG and offered its expertise in a particular science relating to meditation. The *sansthan* (institution) had been founded by S. N. Goenka, an Indian of Burmese origin. He had learnt the science of *Vipassana* from his teacher Sayagyi U Ba Khin, a Burmese meditation master. This is an age-old science, which, it is claimed, was rediscovered by Lord Buddha about 2500 years ago. 'The technique', as disclosed by Ram Singh (retired secretary in the Department of Home Affairs, Rajasthan), 'is one of meditation wherein the *Vipassvi* learns to observe himself observing the truth as it is, which then enables him to explore himself.' He further explained:

> One experiences for oneself that mind and matter are so interrelated that at the moment a thought comes to mind it manifests itself as a reaction in the body, whether it be pleasant or unpleasant or neutral. Then one can evaluate the thought in the mind and understand its true nature. By that understanding alone can one deal with one's thoughts. Reaction ceases and action begins. This enables one to gain mastery over the mind so that one is better positioned to interact with the world outside. Steadily, through this technique, one is able to go in for introspection and, on the other hand, to purify the mind. This is the path to becoming pure, peaceful and happy.

This technique was explained to the inmates of Tihar and about 70 of them volunteered to undergo the ten-day course. One barrack was made available exclusively to them and to Ram Singh. The *Vipassvis* undertook a vow of silence for this period and there was to be no communication among them. The day would start at 4 a.m. with eight hours of meditation scattered throughout the day. For the first three days this meditation consisted of merely trying to be aware of one's breath as one inhaled and exhaled. If there was any physical discomfort like itching, the mind was to ignore it. In the remaining seven days, one then attempted to become aware of the various body sensations. Such acts of observation and control would start a process of purification leading to total emancipation from suffering. This, in turn, would change the complete personality of the individual. Later, many other inmates also volunteered.

On being asked whether this course had proved effective, Kiran admitted most enthusiastically that it certainly had:

> We knew this from the 100-odd prisoners and staff members who had undergone this course. There was a remarkable change in them – I could safely say to an extent of 95 per cent. Most had given up drinking and smoking. But the main thing was that there came about a tremendous change in their attitudes. A number of them even admitted their crimes. This was never so